

GS Parallelism

WHAT THIS STRUCTURE MEANS

Parallelism is the use of matching grammatical structures to express ideas of equal weight or in deliberate contrast. At ILR 3, parallelism is a discourse-level tool — it signals to your listener that you are in control of your argument's structure. When you say 'the question is not whether we act, but how we act, and at what cost,' you are using parallel structure to organize a complex idea clearly and forcefully. Parallelism makes abstract arguments followable and gives your reasoning a sense of deliberate design.

WHAT TO TRY

- Balance two or more ideas using matching grammatical forms: not X but Y, both X and Y, either X or Y
- Use parallel structure to compare policy options, stakeholder positions, or competing values
- Use three-part parallel lists to build analytical momentum: X, Y, and — most importantly — Z
- Use parallel negative construction to reframe a debate: the issue is not X; it is Y
- Align parallel clauses deliberately so the contrast or connection is impossible to miss

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "The question is not whether to act, but when to act and at what scale."
- "Some prioritize efficiency; others prioritize equity; few address how the two interact."
- "This is not a problem of resources — it is a problem of distribution."
- "The more access expands, the more the quality of that access must be examined."
- "What works at the individual level, the institutional level, and the systemic level are three different things."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

Topic: Should higher education be publicly funded?

*"The debate over public funding for higher education is often framed as a choice between **individual benefit and collective cost** — but this framing misses the point. **The more educated a population is, the more productive, the more civically engaged, and the more adaptable** that society tends to be. The question is **not whether education produces returns, but who captures those returns** and who bears the cost. **A system that privatizes the gain while socializing the debt** is not a market solution — **it is a subsidy structured to look like one**. What is needed is **not less investment, but more deliberate investment, distributed on the basis of social return rather than individual ability to pay.**"*

Bold phrases mark active parallelism — matching structures that clarify contrast, build analytical momentum, and signal deliberate argument design.